the Tsurphu monastery in Tibet in the Tolung Valley, not far from the capital Lhasa. It traces its founding to Dusum Khyanpa, the first Karmapa (1110–1193 CE) and there have been seventeen reincarnations since. After the revolt in Tibet in 1959, the sixteenth reincarnation, Rangjung Rigpe Dorje, also went into exile to India, like the Dalai Lama. He made the Rumtek monastery in Sikkim the alternative Kagyu seat in India.

The traditional Black Hat, said to have been woven from the hair of a female goddess, a dakini, is said to be stored in the Rumtek monastery. The sixteenth Karmapa died in 1981, but there are two rival reincarnations to continue his legacy, one born in China and the other in India. It is the former, Ogyen Trinley Dorje, who was recognized as the Karmapa by the Chinese government in 1992, and also later by the Dalai Lama. In 1999 at the age of fourteen, Dorje made a mysterious escape from China and landed up at Dharamsala, where he stayed in exile and was tutored by the Dalai Lama. There have been suspicions among Indian intelligence agencies that he is a Chinese spy, but there is no evidence for this. The Karmapa left India to travel abroad in 2018 and has remained abroad so far. It is reported that he now holds a Dominican passport. He has complained bitterly about the restrictions placed on his activities and movements while in India and the constant suspicion he has been subjected to. I met the Karmapa a couple of times, first as Foreign Secretary in 2005 and then later on a visit to Dharamsala in 2017. From my conversations with him, I have the impression that he is an unusually intelligent young monk with a strong yet pleasing personality, but quite embittered about the manner in which he has been treated by Indian officialdom. The rival Karmapa has now married and in effect dropped out of the race to be recognized as the authentic reincarnation. It is possible that Ogyen Trinley Dorje, recognized by the Dalai Lama, will return to India eventually. His presence in India may become another contentious issue between India and China, though I am not aware whether the Chinese government has raised this officially with the Indian government.

~